

Built for speed

Orcas are the fastest of all sea mammals, but most whales are pretty swift swimmers. Their torpedo-shaped bodies are perfect for cutting through the water.

A short, stiff neck helps the whale to swim fast.

Different species of whale have differently shaped beaks. Some have no beak at all.

A stiff neck?

Some whales, such as the orca, cannot turn their heads from side to side because their neck bones are fused together. This is a useful adaptation to life in the water and allows the whale to reach high speeds.

A whale's front flippers, or forelimbs, are used to change direction.

A streamlined body helps the whale to swim.

Left a bit, right a bit...

The large front flippers help to control direction. A dolphin shows how effective this is when picking off small fish from a large shoal.



Up, down, up, down

A whale's tail moves up and down to push the animal through the water, unlike a fish, whose tail moves from side to side.



Powerful muscles tighten and relax to pull the tail up and down.